

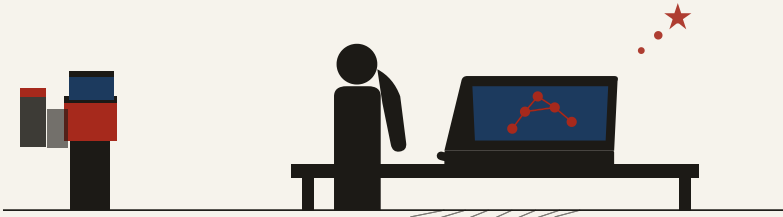
THE CAMPUS EDGE

INDEPENDENT REPORTING ON THE BUSINESS AND LIFE OF THE UNIVERSITY
CAMPUS & EDUCATION

AI on Campus: The Homework Question Dividing Universities

Three years after chatbots first slipped into student laptops, colleges still cannot agree on a single rule — and the disagreement is now showing up in course syllabi, faculty meetings and the job market alike.

BY LI XIAONAN · CAMPUS DESK



A first-year student works alongside an AI writing tool during a late-night study session.

Illustration · Staff Artist

Walk into two lecture halls on the same corridor of the same university this term, and you may find two entirely different laws governing the same technology. In one, a philosophy professor forbids any use of generative AI, down to a grammar check. In the next, an engineering lecturer requires students to log every prompt they send to a chatbot as part of their grade. Nobody in the building can tell you which policy is official, because there isn't one.

That patchwork is the real story behind the now-familiar debate over whether students should be allowed to use artificial intelligence on their assignments. Two and a half years after large language models entered daily use, most universities have stopped asking whether students are using the tools — internal surveys suggest nearly all of them are — and started asking what, exactly, they are allowed to use them for.

"The tool didn't create this problem. It just made visible how differently we already agreed on what counts as a student's own work."

— UNIVERSITY PROVOST, ON THE RECORD

University administrators describe a policy landscape built in a hurry. Early blanket bans, common in the first year after chatbots became mainstream, have mostly softened into disclosure-based rules: students may use AI, provided they say how, and instructors may still deduct marks for over-reliance. A smaller group of departments — often those tied closely to licensing exams, such as nursing or accounting — have gone the other way, tightening restrictions as they worry that heavy AI use masks gaps that will surface later in a professional setting.

Employers, meanwhile, are sending a different signal. Several recruiters interviewed for this piece said they now expect graduates to arrive fluent in AI-assisted work, not innocent of it, because the tools are already stan-

An informal poll conducted by this newspaper across three faculties this spring found that four in five undergraduates had used an AI tool for coursework in the past month, most commonly to summarize readings, restructure an argument, or debug code. Fewer than one in three said a professor had ever explained, in writing, what counted as acceptable use in that specific class.

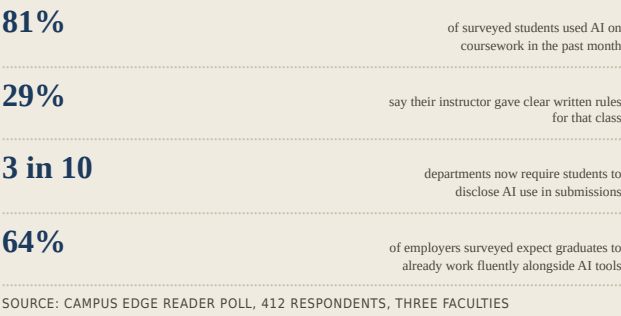
"We are asking eighteen-year-olds to read the room in every single classroom they walk into," said one third-year sociology student, who asked not to be named because she feared it could affect a grade dispute currently under review. "One professor's help is another professor's violation."

dard in entry-level roles across law, consulting, marketing and software. That has left academic integrity offices holding two conflicting mandates at once: protect the meaning of a degree, and prepare students for a workplace that looks nothing like the classroom rules were built for.

What almost everyone agrees on is that the current approach — one policy per professor, revised every semester — cannot hold much longer. Several deans interviewed said a university-wide framework is now being drafted, though none would commit to a date. Until then, the questions is being answered course by course, and often, student by student.

(Continued on Page 2)

BY THE NUMBERS



WHAT OTHER SCHOOLS ARE DOING

Full disclosure model — AI use is permitted everywhere, provided students attach a short note on what was used and why.

Course-by-course model — no institutional policy; each instructor sets and publishes their own rule on the syllabus.

Tiered-risk model — AI is open for early coursework, restricted for capstone and licensing-linked assessments.

Assessment redesign — some departments are replacing take-home essays with in-class writing and oral defense instead of policing AI at all.

The Case For

Supporters argue that treating AI as contraband ignores how work is already done outside the classroom. If graduates will use these tools on day one of a job, the argument goes, a degree that pretends otherwise is teaching a skill nobody will use.

Proponents also point to access: AI can level the field for students writing in a second language, or students with disabilities that make first-draft writing slower, by handling mechanical tasks so effort can go toward the actual argument.

Used well, they add, AI frees time that used to go into formatting and first drafts, leaving more of the term for the harder work — deciding what to say, not just how to say it.

The Case Against

Critics counter that writing is not just a way to present a finished thought — it is how students discover what they think in the first place. Skip the struggle, they warn, and the thinking skill never fully forms.

There is also a fairness problem in the other direction: premium AI tools and subscriptions are not distributed evenly, so easy access can just as easily widen gaps between students as close them.

Finally, opponents note that AI tools still generate confident, plausible-sounding errors. A student who cannot tell fabricated information from real information, they argue, has not actually gained a shortcut — only a new way to be wrong.

Five Questions For

1. How has your office's approach to AI changed in the past year?

A year ago we were still writing rules to close loopholes. Now we've stopped trying to write a rule for every possible tool, because the tools change faster than our committee meets. We've moved toward asking instructors to define what skill an assignment is actually testing, and then deciding from that what kind of AI use would undermine it. It's slower to explain, but it survives longer than a list of banned software.

2. What's the biggest misconception students have about AI detection tools?

That we lean on them heavily, and that they're reliable. We've largely stopped using automated detectors for grading decisions, because the false-positive rate is high enough to punish innocent students, particularly those writing in a non-native language. Most cases we actually pursue come from a mismatch between a student's in-class work and their submitted work, not from a score a piece of software generated.

3. Should the rules be the same in every department?

No, and I'd be worried if they were. A creative writing seminar and an introductory statistics course are testing completely different things. What should be consistent is the process — every syllabus should say, in plain language, what's allowed for that specific class — not the content of the rule itself.

4. What would you say to a student who feels like using AI is basically cheating on training wheels?

I'd ask them what the training wheels are actually for. If a student uses AI to skip the thinking, they've lost something real, and it usually shows up later, often on an exam or in a job. If they use it to handle a mechanical step so they can spend more time on the argument, that's closer to using a calculator in a class that isn't testing arithmetic. The tool isn't the issue. What it replaces is.

5. If you could set one universal policy tomorrow, what would it be?

Not a policy about AI at all, honestly. I'd require every course to state, on the first page of the syllabus, exactly what skill each major assignment is meant to build. Once that's written down clearly, the AI question mostly answers itself, course by course. Right now we're arguing about the tool because we skipped the harder conversation about what we're actually trying to teach.

DR. ELAINE MORROW
DIRECTOR, OFFICE OF ACADEMIC INTEGRITY
NORTHFIELD UNIVERSITY

The Student's Dilemma: Where Help Ends and the Shortcut Begins

For most undergraduates, the question was never whether to use AI. It's how to use it without quietly losing the thread of their own education.

BY LI XIAONAN · CAMPUS DESK



Students and staff take part in a panel discussion on how AI is being used across different fields of study.

Photo · Supplied

Jordan Alvarez keeps two windows open on most nights: the essay, and the chatbot. Not because the senior political science major wants the AI to write the paper, but because talking through an argument out loud — even to software — is how the ideas start to take shape. "I use it the way I used to use a study group," Alvarez says. "Except a study group isn't available at 1 a.m., and it doesn't get tired of my bad first drafts."

That description captures something most policy debates miss: for many students, AI use isn't a single decision but a dozen small ones a week, each in a different class, under a different rule, with no consistent way to tell which side of the line they're on. Alvarez describes toggling between a philosophy seminar where any AI use must be logged in a footnote, and an economics course where a professor has never mentioned the tools at all — leaving students to guess.

The uncertainty produces its own kind of stress. "You start second-guessing totally normal things," Alvarez says, "like whether running a grammar check counts as the same thing as generating a paragraph." Several classmates, Alvarez adds, have simply stopped using AI in some courses out of caution, even in cases where it would likely have been allowed — a chilling effect that rarely shows up in official statistics.

Cost is the other pressure point rarely discussed in faculty meetings. The free versions of most AI tools are noticeably weaker than the paid tiers, and Alvarez says that gap is visible in classmates' work. "Whoever can afford the twenty-dollar-a-month version is basically getting a better tutor," Alvarez says. "That's not really about effort anymore."

What Alvarez wants isn't fewer rules or more freedom, but clarity delivered early and in writing — the same plain-language expectation a professor would set for citing a source. "Nobody our age thinks the technology should be banned," Alvarez says. "We just want to stop guessing what's going to get us in trouble."

That guessing game has quietly become its own subject. In study groups that once traded reading notes, conversation now drifts toward comparing which professors actually check for AI use and which don't — a kind of institutional knowledge students pass down the way they once passed down which lecturers gave easy grades. "It's become something you have to learn on top of the actual coursework," Alvarez says, "figuring out the room before you figure out the assignment."

AT A GLANCE

CLASS YEAR	Senior
MAJOR	Political Science
MOST-USED AI TOOL	Chatbot, for outlining and talking through arguments
POLICY AT THEIR SCHOOL	Set course-by-course, no single university rule
TIME ON AI TOOLS WEEKLY	Roughly 6–8 hours, mostly outlining and research

"Nobody our age thinks the technology should be banned. We just want to stop guessing what's going to get us in trouble."

— JORDAN ALVAREZ, SENIOR, POLITICAL SCIENCE

Five Questions For

1. When do you personally draw the line between using AI as a tool and letting it do the work for you?

If it's helping me organize something I already understand, that feels fine. If I'm asking it to tell me what to think about a reading I haven't actually done, that's the line. The test I use is whether I could explain my own paper out loud afterward without looking at it.

2. Have you ever been unsure whether using AI in a class would get you in trouble?

All the time. Some professors treat a grammar check like it's the same thing as writing a paragraph for you, and others don't mention AI at all, so you're left guessing which category you're in. I've deleted work I was allowed to keep, just to be safe.

3. Do you think the free version of these tools is enough, or does that create a gap between students?

It creates a real gap. The paid versions are noticeably better at the kind of feedback that actually helps you improve, and not everyone can pay for that every month. It's not really about who works harder anymore, in some classes.

4. What's something professors get wrong about how students actually use AI?

That we're all trying to get out of doing the work. Most people I know use it more like a sounding board than a machine that writes the essay. The students actually trying to cheat were probably going to find a way to do that before AI existed too.

5. If you were writing the rulebook, what's the one rule you'd want every class to follow?

Just write it down. One paragraph on the syllabus saying what's allowed for that specific class. It doesn't even have to be generous, it just has to exist, so we're not all quietly making different guesses about the same rule.

JORDAN ALVAREZ
SENIOR, POLITICAL SCIENCE
NORTHFIELD UNIVERSITY

From the Lectern: Why One Professor Rebuilt Her Course Around AI

Rather than ban the technology, a longtime writing instructor redesigned her assignments so the thinking can no longer be outsourced.

BY LI XIAONAN · CAMPUS DESK



University departments are under growing pressure to write clear, consistent rules on AI use.

Photo · Supplied

Two years ago, Renata Kim noticed her students' essays had started to sound alike. Not identical, exactly — but smoothed in the same way, arguments arriving fully formed with no visible trace of the false starts and clumsy first attempts that used to fill her students' drafts. "The writing got better and less honest at the same time," says Kim, an associate professor of English at Northfield University. "That's when I knew the assignment itself was the problem, not the software."

Kim's first instinct, like many instructors', was to tighten the rules. She tried an AI-detection tool for one semester and abandoned it after it flagged several strong, entirely human-written essays while missing others she suspected were not. "I was making accusations based on a percentage a piece of software gave me," Kim says. "I wasn't comfortable putting a student's academic record on that."

Instead, she rebuilt the course. Major essays are now drafted in stages, with early brainstorming stages explicitly open to AI use, but each draft is followed by a short in-person conversation where students explain their own reasoning and revisions out loud. A portion of the final grade now comes from an in-class, closed-laptop writing session that mirrors the argument developed at home. "If the ideas are actually theirs," Kim says, "they can produce a rougher version of the same argument under different conditions. If they can't, that tells me something too."

The redesign was not free. Kim estimates the oral check-ins add several hours of grading time per section, a real cost in a department already stretched thin, and one she acknowledges is harder to replicate in lecture courses with two hundred students instead of twenty. Still, she says the trade-off has been worth it: for the first time in several semesters, she says she trusts that a grade reflects the student who earned it.

Kim is careful not to present her approach as the only answer. "I'm not trying to catch anyone," she says. "I'm trying to build an assignment where using AI to skip the thinking just doesn't work as a strategy, whether or not I ever find out."

Other departments have started asking Kim to walk them through the redesign, though she's quick to warn that it doesn't scale neatly. A twenty-student seminar can absorb the extra oral check-ins; a two-hundred-student lecture course would need teaching assistants trained to run the same conversations consistently, which is its own budget question most departments haven't answered yet.

AT A GLANCE

DEPARTMENT	English
YEARS TEACHING	14
COURSE REDESIGNED	Academic Writing II
NEW POLICY	AI allowed at brainstorming stage only, disclosed in a process log
EXTRA GRADING TIME	Several hours per section, mostly oral check-ins

"I'm not trying to catch anyone. I'm trying to build an assignment where using AI to skip the thinking just doesn't work as a strategy."

— PROF. RENATA KIM, ENGLISH DEPARTMENT

Five Questions For

PROF. RENATA KIM
ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR OF ENGLISH
NORTHFIELD UNIVERSITY

1. What was the moment you realized your old assignments no longer worked?

A batch of essays came in that were technically strong and completely interchangeable in voice. Nothing was factually wrong, but nothing sounded like the students I'd talked to in office hours either. That gap between the writing and the person was the signal.

2. Why not just ban AI outright instead of redesigning the course?

Because I can't enforce a ban I can't verify, and I don't want to build a class around suspicion. Redesigning the assignment so the thinking has to show up somewhere I can see it felt more honest than policing a tool I can't actually monitor.

3. How do students react when a class asks for more in-person work?

Mixed, honestly. Some are relieved to have a clear structure. Others find the oral check-ins stressful at first, which tells me those conversations were doing real work that a purely written assignment wasn't.

4. Has this made your job harder or easier?

Harder in terms of hours, easier in terms of conscience. I spend more time grading than I used to, but I no longer spend energy wondering whether I'm reading a student's thinking or someone else's.

5. What would you say to a colleague who still bans AI completely?

I'd ask what happens when a student breaks that rule quietly, because some will. A ban you can't enforce isn't really a policy, it's a hope. I'd rather build a class where the rule doesn't need to be enforced to work.

Recruiters say they've largely stopped asking whether graduates use AI, and started asking whether they can tell when it's wrong.

BY LI XIAONAN · CAREERS DESK



Graduates are entering a job market being reshaped by AI at every level.

Photo · Supplied

Whitaker expects the gap between AI-fluent and AI-dependent graduates to keep widening over the next few hiring cycles, which is why the firm has started flagging it explicitly in offer letters: new hires are told, in writing, that they will be expected to explain and defend any AI-assisted work during their first performance review, not just produce it.

INDUSTRY	Technology / software
ENTRY-LEVEL HIRES PER YEAR	~150
AI USE IN THE ROLE	Daily, across nearly every team
BIGGEST HIRING RED FLAG	Can't explain their own submitted work
INTERVIEW FORMAT SHIFT	More live reasoning, fewer take-home exercises
TIME TO FILL A ROLE	About 5 weeks, from posting to signed offer

— SAM WHITAKER, HEAD OF EARLY-CAREER RECRUITING

SAM WHITAKER
HEAD OF EARLY-CAREER RECRUITING
A MID-SIZE TECHNOLOGY FIRM

Use the tools, don't fear them, but never submit anything you can't defend line by line if someone asks. That habit alone will put you ahead of most candidates we see.

The Long View: Can Universities Ever Agree on an AI Policy?

A higher-education researcher argues the real failure isn't too much AI on campus — it's too little agreement on what a degree is supposed to certify in the first place.

BY LI XIAONAN · CAMPUS DESK



AI tools are reaching students long before they ever set foot on a university campus.

Photo · Supplied

Zoom out far enough, says Priya Nandakumar, and the current panic over AI in the classroom starts to look familiar. "Calculators were going to end mathematical reasoning. The internet was going to end research skills. Spellcheck was going to end the ability to spell," says Nandakumar, a higher-education policy researcher. "Each time, the technology won, the panic faded, and the actual question — what are we teaching, and why — got answered a little late and a little reluctantly."

What makes this wave different, in Nandakumar's view, isn't the technology itself but the speed of it, arriving campus-wide within a single academic year rather than spreading gradually over a decade. That speed, more than the tool, is what has left individual professors improvising policy in real time, with almost no shared infrastructure to draw on. "We're asking each instructor to independently solve a problem that's actually institutional," Nandakumar says. "That's a design failure, not a discipline failure."

Nandakumar's research points to a quieter risk hiding underneath the day-to-day disagreements: inequality between institutions, not just between students. Well-resourced universities can afford committees, pilot programs and revised assessment models. Under-resourced ones, often serving the students least able to absorb another disadvantage, are left with a stark choice between an unenforceable ban and no policy at all. "The gap doesn't show up in the debate," Nandakumar says. "It shows up two years later, in who employers trust more."

Rather than a single universal rule, Nandakumar argues for treating this as a research problem before a policy problem: small, monitored pilots that test specific approaches — disclosure requirements, redesigned assessments, oral defenses — against actual learning outcomes, with findings shared across institutions instead of reinvented in isolation at every school. "Right now almost every university is running the same experiment alone and calling it a policy," she says. "None of them are comparing notes."

Asked how the moment will look in hindsight, Nandakumar is cautiously optimistic. "In ten years, I don't think we'll be arguing about the tool anymore," she says. "I think we'll have finally written down, clearly, what a university degree is supposed to prove that a chatbot can't. We were overdue for that conversation before AI ever showed up."

AT A GLANCE

FOCUS AREA	Higher-education technology policy
YEARS RESEARCHING ED-TECH	9
CITED PRECEDENT	Calculators entering classrooms in the 1970s
KEY RECOMMENDATION	Pilot-test policies across institutions before mandating them

"Right now almost every university is running the same experiment alone and calling it a policy. None of them are comparing notes."

— DR. PRIYA NANDAKUMAR, HIGHER-EDUCATION POLICY RESEARCHER

Five Questions For

1. Is this panic over AI really different from past waves of technology panic?

The underlying pattern isn't new, but the speed is. Past technologies gave institutions years to adjust. This one arrived across every campus in roughly a single semester, which is why the response looks so improvised.

2. Why do you think universities are struggling so much to agree on a single policy?

Because we're treating it as a discipline problem to be solved by individual instructors, when it's actually an institutional design problem. Nobody handed professors the infrastructure to solve it well, so they're each solving it alone.

3. Could strict AI rules end up worsening inequality between students?

Between students, and between institutions. A well-funded university can redesign assessments and monitor outcomes. A stretched one is often left choosing between an unenforceable ban and no policy at all, and that gap tends to show up later, quietly.

4. What would a research-backed approach to this problem actually look like?

Small, monitored pilots of specific approaches, measured against real learning outcomes, with results shared openly across schools instead of each institution reinventing the same experiment in isolation.

5. Ten years from now, how do you think we'll look back on this moment?

I think we'll see it as the moment universities were finally forced to write down what a degree is supposed to prove that a chatbot can't produce on its own. That conversation was overdue before AI ever entered the picture.

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